Whispering About Whatever

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Whispering About Whatever

by 4theHonourofGräysküll (AVAwolfpack), But_Its_For_Science (DakianDelomast), DakianDelomast

Summary

Catra: ... We used to have those.

Glimmer: What?

Catra: Sleepovers, me and Adora, when we were cadets in the Horde. We'd play tricks on Kyle, stay up all night whispering about--you know, whatever.

As Long As We Have Each Other

The barracks glared a soft green, the air humming with the buzzing lights and the creaking of pipes adjusting with the ambient heat. The cadets of the Horde snored and breathed gently, exhausted from their hard day of training. If one listened closely, amid all the other whitenoise inherent to the Fright Zone were the suppressed giggles of two girls.

They lay side by side together in a bunk, blanket pulled up over their heads. It was almost like they were in another place—another world when they were together like this. Catra's eyes glowed within the darkness of their blanket fort. Adora always liked the way they glowed.

Catra put her hand over Adora's mouth in an attempt to contain her mirth. "Shh! You're gonna wake Lonnie up."

She pulled Catra's hand away, grinning giddily. "Do it again."

"Only if you promise to keep quiet."

"I promise, I promise!"

Catra's eyes narrowed slightly, but Adora knew she wouldn't care if they woke up the entire bunkroom. She took a moment to ease the smirk from her face before she transformed. Her mouth downturned into a broad grimace, revealing her fangs. She crossed her eyes, brow furrowing. Shaking out her mane to poof it up even more, she said in a low growl, " *I'm Force Captain Grizzlor. I smell weird and have a stupid beard.* "

Adora choked on her snicker. Her forehead connected with Catra's chin as she doubled over with barely contained laughter. Catra hissed but it turned into a chuckle.

"Watch it! Your giant forehead is hard as a rock."

Adora shoved her, huffing indignantly. “I don’t have a *giant* forehead.”

“You could land a skiff on that thing.”

Catra pushed her back and they playfully exchanged a few more elbows and jabs before devolving into muted laughter, curling into each other. Beneath the safety of the blanket, there was nothing that could happen to them. Here, they could just be. Adora observed the smile on Catra’s face, unable to help the one on her own.

“I got an impression,” Adora said.

Catra cocked an eyebrow. “You? An impression? This I have to see.”

“Okay, give me a second.” She closed her eyes and pictured her muse. Catra might have been the better actor, but she could pull this off. She scrunched up her eyes in an attempt to look mean. From within, she summoned a deep, roaring growl that cut off halfway through with a snort.

“What was that?” Catra demanded.

Adora could barely speak around her laughter. “Guess.”

“Constipated Hordak?”

“Shut up!” She bumped Catra lightly on the shoulder.

“Adora, I seriously have no idea what that was supposed to be.”

She sighed and pouted. “I was trying to be Rogelio.”

Catra burst out cackling and this time it was Adora clamping a hand over her mouth and telling her to shush. She was better in her recovery and they slipped into a silence that stood on the precipice of more laughter at any moment. The air beneath the

blanket was hot and stagnant, smelling of their breath and their sweat. Adora felt the soft flick of Catra's tail on her leg.

"You ever wondered why Rogelio talks like that?"

"I think he just pretends so he doesn't get in trouble when something goes wrong." There was an undertone of bitterness in Catra's voice that Adora recognized. The day's training had ended abruptly when Kyle had nearly disappeared into the simulation floor. Rogelio was supposed to have been his teammate, but Catra had been closer, so Sergeant Cobalt docked her the points instead.

The smile was gone from Catra's face. Though her eyes were close, Adora could tell they were distant, far off on some thought. Adora didn't know what to say. She'd tried to say so many things before, but none of it ever came out right. None of it had changed anything. The only thing Adora could do was work hard to keep the attention off Catra, and then in these moments, when it was just the two of them, try to make her feel better.

She nudged Catra to draw her back to the present. "Do you wanna see my impression of Kyle falling?"

"Is it gonna be as bad as the last one?" A small smirk tugged at the corner of Catra's lips.

"I dunno. You tell me." Adora grabbed Catra by the shoulders and pushed against them to create the illusion she was hanging on for dear life. She contorted her face into a mixture of surprise and fear. "Ah! Catra help! I'm gonna die!"

She knocked Adora's hands off her and pushed gently against her chest. "You're such an idiot."

That soft melodic chuckle of hers. Every time Adora heard it, she felt warm and calm. She grinned smugly, feeling prideful that she was the only one that could make Catra laugh like that. And Catra was the only one that could make her feel at ease. For as long as she could remember.

Catra's grin relaxed and Adora saw the person she felt like she had always known. Like they'd been born together. There had to be a beginning. Some time when they didn't know each other. But as long as she had memories, Catra had been there with her. That small, spiky-haired girl was here with her now. And it felt right.

They belonged together.

But somehow that still didn't always make sense.

"Do you ever wonder…" Adora started but the thought got away from her. She wasn't quite sure how to say it.

Catra tilted her head. "Wonder what?"

Adora laid her face against the back of her hand, trying to wrangle in her thoughts. "Just… like how the Horde rescued us when we were babies. Do you ever wonder where we came from? If we… if we had families?"

"Where's this coming from?" Catra expression slackened, her eyes drifting.

"I dunno. I was just thinking." Adora shifted closer to her, somehow feeling a small breech in the safety of their blanket fort. She didn't want anyone to overhear. Didn't want this to escape this space between the two of them. "'Cause like, there are others that are like Rogelio or Octavia around. They've always been here. Their parents live in the Fright Zone."

"Right. So?" Catra's mood slipped away from the humor of just a few moments ago.

Adora wanted to stop, but the questions felt like they were too big to hold back. "There are other kids that were rescued from the princesses and are given homes here. Kind of like us. Right? And all those kids from the orphanage. But you and me… Shadow Weaver picked us. Does that mean we're different?"

Catra scowled as though Adora had just offended her. "I dunno if she *picked* me. She acts like I was just *dumped* on her instead." There was that bitterness again. Adora hated that she'd brought it back.

"She's not always bad."

Catra trailed a finger between them, watching it morosely. Her claw caught on the pilling of the blanket before breaking loose. "I guess there are some days she doesn't yell at me or make me mop the bathrooms."

"See! And she put us together and I just… wonder sometimes, I guess." Adora dropped her eyes. "I dunno. I just feel different. Like… like I don't belong here or something."

" *You* not belonging?" Catra scoffed and shook her head. "Give me a break, Adora. You're the top cadet. Everyone loves you. What do you have to feel wrong about?"

"Nothing, I guess." She shouldn't have said anything. She wasn't even sure what she meant. It had just been a feeling she had sometimes. She couldn't help it. Maybe she had just been hoping Catra felt the same way or at least knew about that feeling too, but it seemed she was the only one.

Catra's tail brushed her leg again before she reached and grabbed her arm. "Hey," she said, drawing Adora's attention back. "We can be each other's family, got it? You and me. That's all that matters."

The grin that stretched across Adora's face was slow and hesitant, but the sincerity in Catra's eyes, the conviction, fortified it into a full, broad smile. "I like that."

"Good." Catra returned her smile, before it dropped away. She tilted her head. "So what does a family do anyway?"

"I dunno. Uh…" Adora tapped her chin as she thought. "I guess maybe they just look alike?"

Catra rolled her eyes. “Adora, we look nothing alike.”

“Hey! We kinda do. Like… you have one blue eye and I have two. That counts.”

“No it doesn’t, dummy.” She flicked Adora on the forehead.

Adora frowned and rubbed the spot. “Fine. What’s your idea then?”

Catra didn’t respond right away. Her eyes wandered, and as something occurred to her, her ears flattened shyly and a slight blush rose in her cheeks. She tucked a little closer to Adora and said quietly, “Maybe families look out for each other.”

“Like beat up people when they pick on the other one?” Adora made a punching motion against the bed.

“Yeah.” Catra’s grin was infectious. “And they find secret places in the Fright Zone where they can hide out from everyone in between training.”

“You always find the best hiding spots.” Adora’s eyes lit up and she scooted that much closer to Catra. Their faces were only inches apart, but what they were saying seemed sacred. Something that couldn’t leave the sanctity of their proximity. “And what if they sneak each other ration bars to cheer each other up?”

“But only the gray kind.”

“Deal.”

The smiles they shared could light up the entirety of the Fright Zone. Adora was glad it was contained within their blanket fort. Just between them. There wasn’t much in her life that Adora could claim as her own—the Horde shared everything—but this was something that she wanted all to herself. She knew what it was like to be scared and brave and tired. But in this moment, she thought she knew what it was like to be happy, too.

A hint of doubt wedged in among everything else. This new thing they were making tonight, it felt almost dangerous. Or fragile. She wasn't quite sure.

"You think…" The words faltered. She was afraid again, but as she met Catra's eyes she found her courage. "You think this is what a family does, too?"

Catra's glowing eyes studied Adora's face. The smile was muted, but genuine. "If they don't, they should."

"Our family does then."

"I… okay."

She shuffled closer and tucked her head against Adora's chest. Adora put her arm over her. Whatever hesitancy she'd felt moments before dissipated into the stiff air of the bunkroom as she felt Catra's soft purr vibrate against her chest and they slipped into sleep.

Maybe this was all that mattered.

When We Make the Rules

She flipped her ear around, tracking all over the bunkroom for any sign of anyone still awake. She could recognize their snores, or the way they tossed in their sleep. It seemed safe. She settled back in and her and Adora tucked in close, both hiding under the blanket. Sharing a pillow so close that her breathing caressed through the fur on her face. It'd felt a little different recently. Little crawling feelings in her stomach. She didn't know when exactly they'd started, but they were really nice when they were together like this.

She dropped her voice to a whisper in the serenade of slumber. She wanted to say something about how she was feeling. But she didn't know if Adora was feeling the same way. Instead Catra decided to pick something else to talk about.

"I don't see why we need to be in training all day." She rubbed her arm where the strike of a staff still stung. Adora had said it was an accident. But it still hurt. The course fibers of the blanket tugged and pulled at her fur on her arm. The new issued blankets were a bit more coarse than before and no one could explain why.

"It's pretty fun though. They even gave us some new holograms to fight. That winged one was *super* scary. She had laser blasts and everything. *Pshhhwww* ." Adora's cheeks puffed as she imitated the sound of the winged princess.

"They all have lasers you dummy." Catra smirked and settled her head deeper into the pillow.

"Yeah, but this one was bigger. Sergeant Cobalt said it was the *queen* princess and they were all her minions." Her eyes gleamed with the ambient green light.

Catra reached up her hand between them and scratched a claw delicately over the fabric. Not enough to tear it, but enough to feel the fibers. "You think like Hordak and the soldiers?"

“I think so. But nastier. I can’t wait to fight one of them toe to toe.” Adora rested her head on her arms curled up under the pillow. She had that doofy grin.

Catra shifted her legs under her and their knees touched. There was a quick startle up her back before she regained her smarmy composure. “Funny, that seems like the last thing I’d want to do.”

“I don’t know. I think it’ll be fun. I bet I can get a stun baton blast off before one can take my head off with a magic laser.” Adora held an arm up over her simulating holding a baton out to blast an oncoming princess.

She was such a dork. Catra wondered what she’d think if she ever saw herself. “I guess we’ll just have to find out in a couple years. I just hope the headless one doesn’t show up.”

Adora pulled her arm back protectively and stiffened in alarm. “You think she might?”

“C’mon you don't actually believe that do you? Shadow Weaver was obviously just messing with us.” Catra smirked. Her tail flopped against the bed behind them.

Adora relaxed, taking some comfort in Catra’s words. Sometimes Catra was amazed how someone could be so smart and so gullible at the same time. “What makes you so sure?”

“Trust me.” Catra gently punched Adora in the shoulder.

Adora’s goofy grin returned. “Maybe we should make a hunting party just to be sure.”

“If that means I finally get to drive a tank you can count me in.”

“You think you’ll be tank qualified by then?”

Catra shifted back on the pillow as though to take stock of Adora. “Qualified? When we’re running things, we won’t need qualifications. Skiff rides, extra ration bars, training optional, and I

get to turn Shadow Weaver's stupid gem into target practice with a laser cannon."

Adora's voice dropped into an excited hush. "Ohh I like this game. Hmmm, I think Hordak should give us our rations—" She spread her hands out wide, at least as wide as she could laying on her side. "—on a big plate."

Catra laughed. "I can't imagine how much he'd be growling. What else?"

Another shift in Adora. She squirmed a little in excitement and another feeling rushed through Catra. It snuck through her stomach and into her… her heart? Was that a thing? There was a flutter. She didn't know exactly what it was. She definitely didn't feel it with the other cadets. Maybe that one time with… no that was different. It always felt different with Adora.

"Hmmm, well when we defeat the princesses do you think we could go see their kingdoms?"

Catra raised an eyebrow at her. "Why on Etheria would we do that?"

She shrunk a little and uncertainty filled her voice. "I dunno, maybe it'd be fun to see what they're like when they're not being run by evil people. Maybe we could have adventures out there."

Catra regretted her skepticism already. " *Maybe* it'd be fun. We could take turns running through their traps. First one to die loses." An involuntary smile crept over her lips.

"Okay." Adora smiled in return. "I say we do Plumeria first. I heard there's all kinds of killer venomous plants."

"Deal. Just so long as we don't—"

A rustle across the room stopped Catra's words dead. She couldn't discern who it was, but she didn't want to wake someone

else. Adora started to ask a question and Catra put a hand over her mouth. “Shh.”

Adora nodded and Catra listened. It’d be fine. She waited for the snoring to resume from that side of the room. Hopefully it was just someone turning over in their sleep. As the tension relaxed, she became very aware of her hand over Adora’s mouth. The lips were soft, the breath over her hand warm. She felt so delicate. She was the strongest cadet, but like this she felt so… vulnerable.

So did Catra, but it didn’t bother her.

Adora slowly reached up and grasped around Catra’s wrist. There was that goofy smile again. “I think the coast is clear,” she whispered softly.

Catra blushed and pulled her hand back with a snap. “I was just making sure, idiot.”

Adora’s face fell back into a strange look. One she didn’t often wear. It was a mix between confusion and worry. Her hands lingered up closer to Catra’s in between them. Catra’s breathing shallowed as Adora moved tentatively. One hand venturing across the meager space, fingertip brushing the short tuft of fur on her jaw. An unasked question stretched out between them.

Catra swallowed. “So when we take over—” Adora’s hands stopped their crawl between them. “I think the Horde bat wings are kinda cool, but maybe we should do something else.”

A flicker of disappointment lapsed through Adora’s face, but she relaxed again. “You know, you’re right. They just don’t feel like us.” She tapped a finger to her chin. “Oh! That’s it.”

“What’s it?”

Adora grinned slyly. “It should be *us* .”

Catra rolled her lips over her sharp fangs hiding her own smile. “You think so?”

"Yeah, that'd be the best. Everyone would know Adora and Catra's Horde was there and in charge."

Catra and Adora's Horde sounded better, but she wasn't about to interrupt her. She remembered something. A prize from long ago tucked away in her mattress above. Now was the perfect time to get it. "Hang on."

"Okay." Adora's puzzlement didn't deter her excitement.

Catra flipped the blanket off her and she crawled up the side of their bunk bed to reach under her thin mattress. She withdrew two small cylinders and snuck back to Adora's bunk without making a noise. She curled back under the blankets and held the two markers between them. "Which color do you wanna be?"

Adora's eyes lit in disbelief. "Where'd you get those?"

"The briefing room. Why?"

"You're not supposed to just take things, Catra. You could get in trouble."

"Oh, wow. So you mean I might catch extra shit about running off with two stupid markers?"

Adora flexed her mouth, readying another protest. She looked down, reserved. Finally she met Catra's eyes again. "Okay, I get to be light red."

"You mean pink?"

"I mean *light red* !"

"Fine." Catra smirked and rolled over to face the side of the bed.

"What, you're going to draw them?"

Catra looked back over her shoulder to peer at Adora. "Adora, your drawings suck. You can't map out an encounter in the

simulation room.”

“Whatever, but you gotta draw it like I tell you.”

Catra turned back over to face the side of the bunk and took out the first marker. She started with the *pink* one and drew the oval and circles for her eyes. The stupid hair poof up top, of course, and the long ponytail she’d always had.

“My hair doesn’t look like that.” Adora shifted, crawling over to cross the gap between them and critique her work. She folded along Catra’s back. Her tail twitched between them, pinned by Adora’s legs. The warmth of Adora’s presence enveloped her as she leaned forward to get a better view. Her cheek brushed against Catra’s ear, tickling at the fine, delicate fur and causing a reflexive flick. It was suffocating in the best way possible.

The flutter in her stomach rose into her chest once more. This time it invoked a rumbling purr in her chest. She didn’t want to. She felt like she was saying too much. Catra swallowed, trying to stifle it. “How does it look then?”

If Adora noticed she didn’t bother to point it out. “It isn’t that tall in the front!”

“Oh, you haven’t been paying attention in the locker room.” Catra nudged an elbow back into Adora’s ribs.

She reached over Catra, enveloping her in warmth. She smudged the top of the poof away. “Draw it smaller. And make the ponytail bigger.”

Catra feigned a sigh and drew per her orders. She finished the ears and eyebrows and only one thing was still missing. “Okay, I get to draw the mouth.”

“What? Why?”

“Because.”

Adora grumbled, but repressed her mistrust. Catra drew the bowl at the bottom with the line across the top, and big vertical lines in between.

"What's that?"

"That's your big dopey grin." Catra turned her head a little. She could only really see Adora's chin from here. But it was enough.

"It doesn't look like that!"

"I'm going to pull the training recordings to show you."

Another grumble, but Adora settled back. "Fine, but you gotta draw your mouth like I say."

Catra didn't really like the sound of that, but if it let her keep the smile on the drawing she wasn't going to argue. "Okay."

She switched markers for the blue and started again with the oval. She paused a moment. "How do I draw my hair?"

"That's easy." Adora leaned over and snatched the marker out of Catra's hand and started drawing big spikes all around her head. She wanted to argue, take the marker back. But Adora was over top of her now. And she didn't want to interrupt.

"And you have big ears, too." She drew two triangles on the sides of her head, shading in the upper half for the black tops. "And then the little tufts on the side." The marker moved without thought now. The way she talked turned more flutters inside of Catra's chest. All protests were dimming as Adora continued. She drew the mouth, a straight grumpy line with two fangs poking through, and matched the mischievous eyebrows that Catra had put on the other doodle. Catra didn't realize her purr escaped her control and it reverberated inside of the whole bunk. She blinked and fought back for control of herself. She could focus on the drawing.

It looked perfect. But Catra would never tell her. “That’s terrible.”

“It’s great. You said I’m a bad artist but that looks better than what you drew for me.” Adora dangled the marker in front of Catra.

She took it slowly and Adora settled back. She didn’t back away from behind her though. The warmth was still there. There was one thing missing from the drawing. Something that she wanted. She’d been thinking about it. “I want to add something.”

“What’s that?”

Catra smudged away the top of her forehead, careful not to damage the other lines that Adora had drawn. She put points on the top of her head, and a little jagged line framing her eyes.

“What’d you draw?” Adora leaned over her again, her cheek brushed against Catra’s ear and it flicked in response.

“I…” Catra collected her breathing. “I’ve been thinking about maybe making a mask. Something to wear. My hair looks kinda dumb.”

“If you say so. I think it looks fine.”

Secretly, Catra wished for a more glowing endorsement for her idea. But it still was something. “Maybe someday.” She set the markers down.

“So that’s Adora and Catra’s Horde?” Adora put her hand next to the drawing.

“It’ll be the last thing those princesses see.” Catra placed her hand near Adora’s.

Their fingers were precariously close to touching.

“Awesome.” Adora turned back over and Catra felt the warmth leave her back. She wanted it to stay for a little longer, but it was gone. Like things usually are. But it was nice while it lasted. She capped the markers and stashed them under Adora’s mattress. She wanted to say something before she turned over. That fluttering feeling in her chest hadn’t diminished. She wanted to talk about it. But she knew better. It’d be dumb to say anything now.

She sighed and rolled back over to face Adora. “We should probably get to sleep.”

Maybe another night would be the time to say it.

Adora nodded and the two of them fell into slumber together among the symphony of snores and jostling of the bunkroom.

Take Care of Each Other

Adora's head was pounding. She could barely breathe through the stuffiness of her nose and the constriction of her chest. Her body ached. Even laying down in her bunk hurt. It felt as though she was covered in a bruise from head to toe and she didn't want to move. Which she could barely do anyway. She was shaky and weak. If she had tried to make it to training today, even Kyle would lay her out in just a few hits.

The thought of missing training sent a rush of fear and guilt through her. What would happen? She'd never missed a day of training before. Would they punish her? Demote her to the lowest rank so she was doomed to scrub the floor along with all the scrap bots. Or worse, would they banish her? Send her off to the Crimson Waste to die of starvation and thirst? Or to Beast Island where she'd be cut apart and eaten by the Chibbits or Scruffers…

She threw off her blanket. She couldn't miss training! Not with so much at stake. She had to… had to…

A wave of dizziness surged through her head when she tried to stand. Her limbs were rubbery and useless, unable to support her weight. She collapsed back onto her cot, only managing to have flopped over to the opposite end of the bunk.

She groaned and pulled the blanket up over her head. Anxiety churned in her chest, feeding out into fingers and toes so they tingled. She wanted to move, but couldn't. It hurt to move. Her body was betraying her.

She hated it.

It took her the better part of five minutes to crawl her way back to the top corner of her cot. She curled up into a tiny ball, hoping that no one would notice her. No one could see her this way. Weak and useless. Catra was the one that was good at hiding.

She wished Catra were here right now to hide with her. Maybe that would make her feel better…

She stifled the thought. She couldn't risk dragging Catra down with her. After everything… if this was to be her undoing, she would want Catra unassociated with it. Safe.

Adora smothered her coughs in a knot of the blanket. Each was like a razor against her sternum. She settled again. Her eyes stared dazedly at the doodle on the wall of her bunk. She reached out a shaky hand and traced the jagged edges of Catra's face, the spikes of her mane. The two little points of her fangs. She wondered if Catra was okay without her around for training today. The other cadets always seemed to find a way to pick on her when Adora wasn't there—so she liked to always be there.

She shouldn't let this stop her. She braced herself, pushed off from the cot into a sitting position. The dizziness was there in her head and she swayed with the waves of static through her brain. It wasn't much worse than when she got a good knock during training.

She used the sloping rail of the bunk to pull herself to her feet. Her legs shook beneath her, but she willed them to stay under her. To stay upright. Her socks were slippery on the smooth, hard floor. The blanket slipped from her shoulders. A shiver rolled up her spine. The climate of the Fright Zone was always so hot and stifling, but now Adora felt nothing but a cold chill in the air.

She could work her way through it.

She had to.

Each step was a gamble, but she took them. She made it halfway across the bunkroom when a shadow crept across the floor to her. Edged at the corners of her vision.

Shadow Weaver?

Panic surged through her. She couldn't let Shadow Weaver see her like this. Weak and useless. She couldn't be any of those things. Not when she was supposed to be the next Force Captain. The one that would lead the Horde in crushing the princess rebellion.

Adora tried to pull herself upright. Straightening to attention. She brought her hand up for a salute, her muscles singing with effort. But the shadows gathered around her. Darkening. Building. Encompassing her entire vision until she could see no more.

Adora… Adora!

From the blackness, she heard a voice calling to her. She opened her eyes and through her blurry vision saw a pair of dichromatic eyes. One yellow. One blue. Concern painted so clearly within them. Catra hovered just above her, shaking her awake. So close.

"Catra?"

"What are you doing on the floor, dummy?"

"Catra, I… You shouldn't be here. Where's Shadow Weaver?"

"Shadow Weaver? I don't know. Bothering someone else probably." Catra frowned at her. "I was wondering why you didn't show up to breakfast this morning and I found you like this."

Adora let out a relieved breath, feeling the heaviness of her body. The shiver and the ache. Her heart thudded hard in her chest, dislodging something in her lungs. Rough coughs erupted from her throat. She pressed a fist to her mouth, struggling to repress them.

Catra knelt next to her, rubbing her shoulders while she coughed. Soon they passed, and she said, "Damn, Adora. Are you okay?"

Adora pressed her forehead against the cool floor. “I think I’m dying.”

Catra snorted. “You’re not dying. You’re just sick. C’mon. Let’s get you back to your bunk.”

She helped Adora up from the floor, lifting her by the arms. It always surprised Adora how strong Catra was. She was so small and slim, agile and fast, but when it mattered she knew when to use her strength. Adora felt just a little stronger herself in that moment, knowing she could rely on Catra.

She wasn’t alone anymore.

Catra set her down on the cot and grabbed the tangled blanket from where Adora had left it. She wrapped it around Adora’s shoulders. Adora hadn’t realized how hard she was shivering until the warmth of the blanket enveloped her. The tremors passed up her aching spine. Catra pressed the back of her hand to Adora’s forehead, frowned, and did the same with her forearm.

“You’re burning up.”

Adora groaned. “I knew it. I *am* dying.”

“Don’t be such an idiot. You’re not dying.” She smirked, that left fang poking out from beneath her lip.

Adora found her wavering vision focusing on it. Why was it always that fang?

Catra sat next to her on the cot, close enough that their shoulders were brushing. Adora was thankful for her warmth. “You’ve never been sick before, have you?”

She shook her head. “No. This is awful. I hate it.”

“You’ll be fine. You just need to relax.” The smirk broadened at the horror on Adora’s face. “Actually, relaxing might be what kills you.”

Adora bumped her shoulder. “Don’t joke about that! This is serious.”

“Oh, *so* serious.” Catra's tone dripped with sarcasm that eased some of Adora’s fears. Her tail flicked around her, draping over her opposite shoulder. “Just rest and you’ll be good as new in no time.”

The softness of her fur against her cheek was sending a different kind of fluttering through Adora’s chest. She glanced sideways at Catra. “How do you know so much about it?”

“I’ve been sick before.” She shrugged nonchalantly. “It’s no big deal.”

“You have? When?”

Catra’s expression had turned unreadable. Adora recognized the walls. The barriers. There seemed to be more and more all the time. “A while ago. I don’t remember.”

“Oh.” Adora stared down at her lap, uncertain why this news made her stomach twist painfully. “I didn’t know…”

“Because I was smart enough to hide away until it was over and not pass out in the middle of the barracks for anyone to find me.” Catra hesitated, then turned to Adora. She set a hand on her back. Gentle. Reassuring. “Seriously Adora. Just get some rest and you’ll be okay.”

Adora nodded slowly. Words had escaped her somehow. She was just glad Catra was here with her. So close. Catra was the only person she never had to worry about seeing her as anything but perfect. With Catra, she just didn’t have to worry and that alone already made her feel better.

She felt herself drifting. Whatever strength she’d gleaned from Catra was slipping away and she was fading with it. Catra eased her down onto her pillow, pausing a moment to brush the wayward wisps of her hair from her face. The softness of her

touch seemed to banish the ache with Adora. Everything settled within her.

"What about training?"

"Sleep. I'll cover for you."

Adora caught her hand before she could leave. "You will?"

"Of course, dummy." Catra smiled down at her. "I look out for you. You look out for me. That's what we do."

A wayward thought flitted at the edge of her consciousness. Please stay. Don't go. She wanted to say these things to Catra, wanted her to stay there with her. She couldn't bring herself to say it though. It was selfish. Too risky. She couldn't do that to Catra just because it would make her feel better.

She let Catra's hand go and watched her leave the bunkroom. The door hissed shut behind her, sealing Adora in among the creaking of the pipes and the ambient green glow of the barracks. The urge to force herself up, to go train so nothing bad could happen was still there in her, spinning around and around in her chest. But she was able to ignore it. She trusted Catra. If Catra told her she would be okay, well, Adora was going to believe her.

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The door to the barracks slammed open with a burst of compressed air. Adora startled awake, glancing around in a daze. She was still in her bunk, their little doodle two blurs of color at the edge of her vision. Had any time passed? The bunkroom was always lit by the same lights regardless of the time of day. Adora could have sworn she'd just only closed her eyes a moment before.

Then she saw Catra loping toward her. The puffiness of her tail betrayed her agitation before she was close enough for Adora to make out the wild look in her eyes. She positively leapt into

Adora's cot next to her, landing on the stiff mattress with a quiet thump.

"Catra—what?"

"Scoot over." Catra grabbed the edge of the blanket and crawled underneath it. She wedged her way beside Adora, her head popping up next to hers on the pillow. Her heterochromatic eyes glowed in the low lighting. "I'm *not* here. Got it?"

Adora only nodded. She wondered if this was another hallucination. Maybe she was still dreaming. But she didn't think she was asleep. Otherwise, why would her heart be pounding so hard in her chest?

"Jeez, you're sweaty."

"I'm sorry."

"At least it means your fever broke."

Catra was out of breath, panting hard though she was doing well to stifle the sound of it. Her ears flicked and she shot a quick glance back to the door. Something was wrong. That much Adora could tell around her delirium.

"Are you okay?"

"It's fine." She shifted and brought her hands up between them. "Here. I managed to sneak this."

It took Adora's eyes a moment to notice the ration bar. Was it dinner time already? Had she really slept through the entire day? She shook her head. Focus, Adora.

"Did something happen?"

"Just take the stupid food and eat it, okay?"

Adora's stomach was a mass of knots but she didn't move to take the ration bar from her. She studied Catra, struggling to place the uneasiness within her. Then her eyes alighted on the slight swelling of Catra's cheek, the almost shagginess to her normally sleek fur there. Adora reached up, brushing her fingers across the hard lump. Catra hissed and jerked away.

"Watch it!"

Adora retracted her hand sharply, tucking them up by her chest. She couldn't quite believe she'd just done that. "You're hurt."

Catra scowled, glancing distrustfully down at her hands. "It's nothing. Happened during training."

"But face shots are—"

"Do you think anyone actually cares?" she snapped.

There was a sharpness to Catra's eyes as she glared at Adora. But Adora could see behind it—she could recognize the same fear and pain from when they were little.

"Who did it?" Adora sat up. "Tell me who and I'll—" The dizziness caught up with her and she was helpless to resist against Catra pulling her back down to the pillow.

"It was just a cheap shot during sparring. Caught me off-guard. That's all."

"That's a rules violation. Whoever did it should get cleaning duty for at least a month, or—"

She shoved the ration bar into her chest. "Just eat, okay? It doesn't matter."

"It *does* matter, Catra."

"No. It *doesn't* ." Catra squeezed her eyes shut in frustration, or to hide the tears that were brimming in the corners. Adora had

noticed them, but she wouldn't say anything. "I don't *care* what they do to me because it won't matter soon anyway. Soon we'll be in charge and they can't do anything to us anymore. So…" She pushed the ration bar into Adora's hand gently but insistently. "Eat this and rest so you feel better."

Adora took the ration bar, but still refrained from eating it. She studied Catra. Her eyes were downcast almost shyly, ears laid back flat against her head. The bruise on her cheek was a hard knot just below her eye. Seeing it filled Adora with a sense of anger and frustration. If she wasn't so weak, she could have been there during training today. She could have stopped that staff strike.

"Promise me something," Adora said.

Catra's eyes flicked up to hers in curiosity.

"Tomorrow we'll pay back whoever did that to you."

A sly grin spread across Catra's face, one that matched the doodle on the wall just on the other side of her. "Oh, trust me. I already did."

Adora smirked and broke off the first piece of the ration bar. "Do I want to know?"

"Let's just say Sludge-boy and Bangs are gonna be in hot shit with the quartermaster when he finds all those stolen stun batons in their lockers."

Adora nearly choked on the bar, the dry material catching in her throat. "You did *what* ?"

"I did nothing." Catra shrugged and the mischievous grin on her face solidified. "Sludge-boy and Bangs on the other hand—"

A loud bang on the other side of the barrack's door caused Catra to yelp sharply and dive beneath the blanket. A rush of warmth burst through Adora, warding off the chill pervasive in her

bones today. She held her breath while Catra squirmed before settling into place tucked into a tight ball against her side, afraid if she did anything wrong, Catra would leave. Once in place though, Catra didn't move. She could have easily passed as an extra pillow or blanket Adora was hiding.

Adora chewed through her mouthful of ration bar and watched the door, waiting for someone to come through. She wondered what she would say if someone did. If she could lie her way through it. A few tense moments passed, but the door didn't open. It was probably just metal cooling in the night air.

When she was sure no one was coming, Adora pulled up the edge of the blanket and looked down at Catra. "I think the coast is clear."

Catra's ears flicked. "I might just stay here for a bit anyway."

"Okay." Adora let the blanket drop.

She finished the ration bar, remaining vigilant for any trespassers. When no one came and there was nothing more to eat, she dusted off her hands and ducked under the blanket too. She curved around Catra, so small and unassuming when she was curled up like this. But she was warm and familiar. There were few places Adora would want to be more.

"Are you okay?" she asked, whispering it even though they were alone.

"I'm fine," Catra grumbled, but it sounded more weary than irritated. "Just… get better, okay?"

Adora put her arm over Catra's shoulder. "I'm already feeling better."

"Good."

Her eyes drifted closed. Their shared warmth pulled her swiftly to sleep.

The Mask She Wore

She was dumb.

Why'd she think that it'd be any better? Why'd it matter in the first place?

Catra sat curled up in the corner of the bed, her back against the wall, the blanket curled around her. It always felt so strange in the bunkroom. There were people all around, all the time. But there weren't many places to hide. Not enough to call her own. No, this was as safe as it got. And she learned to hide, even in plain sight.

Maybe it's because no one ever came looking for her.

She still was that child. That one that hid behind the crates when she cried. That one from so long ago. It never got better. No matter how hard she tried nothing ever changed. It was easier to cry alone. Easier to hide. That's what mattered.

It seemed like a good idea. It was a little project. A little thing that she'd been working on. She was strange, and maybe if she just emphasized that a little more, maybe then something would be better? It was just a little project. That was all.

She'd been sneaking away into the forge and scrounging up spare bits of metal. Things that she could melt down. The tools were all there, even if it was mostly automated now, but there were abandoned shops. Ones where the bots never wandered and in the bowels of the Fright Zone anything could happen. It all started when she'd found the scrap red-steel.

She didn't know why it had to be the red-steel. But she always liked it. Maybe it was the familiarity of the color, or the pride she secretly carried. It was that little bit of dark red like a dried bloodstain. It felt powerful. Maybe that's why Shadow Weaver wore it on her mask.

A mask. A new thing to hide behind, but one she could carry around. It was going to be different this time. She didn't need to be scared if she wore it. She'd be a different person, vying for the senior cadet rank, or maybe just the second behind Adora. Adora was going to get the badge. She would be Force Captain before them. Maybe soon Commander with a couple missions under her belt. And Catra could be with her.

Melting down the steel and forging it took time. She had singed some hair off her arms a couple times. Endured the jibs and the looks. But she could cover her arms. They weren't the worst wounds she'd had to hide growing up in the Fright Zone. No, it was easy. And she thought it might've been worth it.

The hammer press had been the hardest part. She'd go to bed worn out, barely able to move her arms. Adora had given her so much shit in their sparring matches. Catra had suffered a few more hits, a few more bruises when she couldn't keep up even with Kyle. But it was done. She'd finished it.

But did it look stupid? She didn't know. Not until she wore it. It was hard sneaking it into the locker room, the only mirror she had access to. But she couldn't wear it before she knew it looked good.

Her hair had been growing out. The stupid tufts at the side of her head were too big, and bangs poked out of the top of her head at a funny angle. The mask could conceal that. She had put it on.

Suddenly everything felt different. She looked different in the mirror. Confident. The stupid tufts were tucked away behind the mask and they seemed to blossom like little streaks of gray fire. Her hair swept back dramatically and was accentuated by the sneering glare at the top of her mask. It wasn't a dumb project. It'd work. It was perfect.

Or so she thought.

She was stupid.

She had strutted right out of the locker room into the bunkroom. She'd caught Octavia looking at her as she passed by. Her eyebrows had shot up in disbelief. There was a pride in Catra's strut through the halls. There might even have been a whistle. She must've just imagined that, though.

As soon as she entered the bunkroom, everything changed. It seemed all right at first. The other cadets looked at her in shock. That seemed like a good sign. What was even better? Adora stared. She looked like a mouse could've bitten her right in the ass and she wouldn't have moved.

It seemed great. It matched her leotard, and it made her feel more confident. A new mask, a new life. One worthy of a senior cadet.

Then Lonnie laughed.

It was a swarm. A pile. It had happened faster than she could keep up and it was worse than any gang-up she'd been through in training. The cadets had lit up with cruel laughter. They had wanted to know if she was trying to look more like an animal or what. Or if she really had wasted all her time the past few weeks making that stupid thing. Not even Adora had stepped in to protect her. She wasn't laughing, but she didn't help, either. She just stood there.

Kyle said he didn't know she wanted to look like Shadow Weaver so bad.

That was it. That was too much.

She threw it away and ran. She ran and ran and ran to where she didn't even really know. She was blinded by tears and driven by sorrow into the deepest parts of the Fright Zone. No one would notice if she was gone.

At least no one cared.

Not even Adora found her then. That's how little she mattered.

It might've been a whole day, maybe even two before she decided it'd be time to sneak back. Not because she needed them. No, that'd be the worst reason. She just needed food. She still wanted to stay out of sight. The pain was too raw. The thought had briefly crossed her mind to hide in the depths of the Fright Zone forever. She could sneak into the barracks at night, grab what she needed, and sneak out. No one would've seen her.

It wouldn't last forever. Shadow Weaver always found her. Dragging her back, making her suffer. Some days it was the only thing that kept her there. The others it was Adora. Catra couldn't face her, though. Not yet, but she could hide in plain sight. She was a ghost that wandered in and out of the bunkroom when no one was there. Hiding in Adora's bed while she and the other cadets were eating or training. She just wanted to be where Adora was, but not around Adora. It was the one thing that Catra allowed herself. A meager comfort. It'd been a week of this.

It hurt, but it felt like the hurt she needed.

So now she sat. Curled up in the blanket that matched the colors of the bunkroom. It was snug around her. And it smelled like Adora. That sweat seemed magical, comforting. Like she was still there. But she wasn't. No one was in the bunkroom right now. They were training or something stupid.

Something she didn't want to be a part of.

She lingered in between tears and exhaustion. It'd been a day since she last ate. Food was more of a labor than a joy. She didn't even have the taste for the gray rations. It didn't matter. She'd avoided Adora so far. Knowing her, she'd want to *talk* about it and that's the last thing Catra wanted. The memories would die with time, just like all the pain she endured.

She'd hid.

Until there was a soft thump on the bed.

Shit. She'd waited too long.

"Catra?" There was a twinge in the voice that almost broke her right there.

She didn't want to break. Not again. Not in front of her. She wanted to keep hiding. Not face them, or anyone.

But that voice compelled her. She could hear it. That really, really strange noise that happened only in Adora's words. Relief.

She always sounded like that when she found Catra.

It was annoying.

Catra unfolded a corner from the blanket and peeked through it with just one eye. Enough to see Adora's face.

She was smiling. How could she smile? Why right now?

She wanted to say something. She wanted Adora to go away. But she couldn't. Instead, there were only two words on her mind.

"Hey, Adora." Her voice cracked and she felt the raw embarrassment from it.

Adora smiled more. Her tears glistened in her eyes and she nudged forward on her knees. Catra felt cornered now, but somehow it was okay if it was Adora. "Are you… okay?"

Why was she the only one that ever asked that?

Catra wanted to say no. She wanted the question to go away. It was a dumb, stupid question. Why'd it matter how she was or if things were all right? It was just a waste of time answering it. But she couldn't deflect it. Adora's blue eyes brimmed with a disarming sincerity that disassembled everything Catra tried to hide inside.

"No…" But she curled her arms around her tighter. Nestled deeper into the blanket. It wasn't okay to be here.

"Can I help?" Adora kneeled with her hands on her knees. A face full of earnestness. Annoying earnestness.

Catra peered out between the folds of the blanket again, looking for a threat. Someone to interrupt them. "Someone's going to be back soon. I need to leave." It wasn't safe here. She didn't want to be exposed.

"They're all eating right now. I snuck out. We should be good for another hour."

"You skipped a meal? What's wrong with you?" She unfolded a little from the blanket but didn't open it up.

Adora smiled and twirled a finger over the bare bedding. It left little wrinkles in the fabric. "Well… I've been… I knew you were around even if I haven't seen you for like a week. I knew you were in my bunk sometimes. Wrinkled bedsheets and stuff. But I couldn't ever catch you. I've been checking."

Hot embarrassment flooded the back of Catra's neck. She'd been such an idiot. Why didn't she remember her training? Vary up your patterns. Don't stick to routines. Routines get you killed. Or caught. Or a very annoying Adora will find you. "Why were you checking?"

"That's a dumb question." The smugness of her voice drew Catra's eyes to the lopsided smile.

She wanted to snap something mean at her. Something to get her away. But it was okay. Why did she like that smile so much?

Catra nodded and she… She opened up the blanket.

Adora knew the cue. She always did. She scooted forward as quickly as she could to crawl into the opening. She was drawn to Catra in an inexplicable gravity that only felt satisfied when they

met. Their arms and bodies intertwined. The heat, the warmth, was instantly inviting, scouring away the cold and dark that haunted Catra for days. That funny feeling snuck inside of her again. The one she didn't know how quite to put into words, but it was always there. Something special she shared with Adora. A purr reverberated between their bodies. It flooded the silence and pushed away the dark and misery. She didn't hold it back this time. She couldn't even if she tried.

They quickly folded around one another in the protection of the blanket. It was easy, natural. She didn't know who leaned on who right then. It didn't matter. They were just tucked away again in the corner of the bed.

"I missed you," Adora softly whispered. The only time she was ever quiet was when they were like this.

Catra leaned in closer to her and she slowly wrapped her arms around her. Why was she the only one that ever missed her? She fought the tears. She fought them so, so hard. Not now, not right then. Maybe she could get away again. Go hide. But Adora had already embraced her, and she knew there was no way of breaking out of those arms. Not without leaving some scratches on Adora, anyway.

There were words that felt unnatural but they were the only ones that she could think of. "I missed you, too." Catra tucked her face onto Adora's shoulder.

She squeezed her. That little bit of appreciation.

Catra wasn't sorry she left. But maybe… A little sorry that she —

No.

It was fine.

But she missed this. She missed this warmth.

Adora leaned back a little. “I’m… I went looking for you, but I couldn’t find you this time. You weren’t in any of our spots, not even on the overlook.”

She went all the way up there looking for her? Catra stifled her disbelief. “I didn’t want to be found. Not this time. I thought I could hide better. And I think I did. There’s a lot of the Fright Zone that I don’t think even Hordak knows about.”

“Well… don’t go there again without me.”

A rebellion rose in her chest. That stupid request, or an order. She was already acting like a Force Captain and it was going to be *awful* when she got that badge. If Catra wanted to hide, she could. What business was it of Adora’s if she wanted to hide?

But the hug didn’t relent. The embrace was tight. And there was that same little tinge of her voice. It was a fear.

It doesn't matter what they do to us, you know? You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.

That stupid dumb promise she signed up for.

“Okay.”

A tighter squeeze told her that was exactly the thing she needed to say. “Maybe we can find something *really* cool down there together.”

More tears. She was having such a hard time fighting them back. A leaking pipe that was about to rupture. A flood of the hurt that she’d been hiding from. But she could bite it down. Hide it away. It’d be fine. It’d be okay. She couldn’t cry. Least of all in front of Adora.

Adora pulled away from her in the blanket. “I did something.”

The soft purring stopped and she went cold. Those words sounded absolutely terrifying right now. What did she mean by that? Catra could only stare.

It didn't seem to fill Adora with any confidence but she moved, anyway. She leaned away, a brief opening of the blanket meant some of the cold wafted in from her departure. It was weird being apart from her right now. Adora reached behind her and her hand disappeared under the mattress. A secret little stash that she kept little things outside of her regular locker.

She clearly didn't want anyone finding this.

She pulled out the mask. The red-steel glinted in the sickly viridescent glow of the bunkroom. Catra wanted to throw it away. Anger burned inside of her. She never wanted to see that stupid thing again. And the dumbass thought she'd keep it? Why? What was wrong with her?

Her thoughts were a mess of anger. She couldn't grab the right words and Adora saw it. There was fear in her eyes. She grasped both sides of the mask as though she could protect herself from the impending onslaught.

But she knew the words that'd stop this whole thing. "I really liked the way it looked."

The anger went cold. Quenched by her blue eyes. She wasn't lying. She'd never lie to her. No this was a raw honesty. One that Catra needed. It was so honest it hurt.

"I'm sorry the other cadets picked on you. And I didn't stand up for you. I was pretty overwhelmed and I couldn't stop them before you ran off. I'm sorry I didn't help you out." She proffered the mask back to her with open hands. "I think if you wore it for a bit, they'd get used to it."

Catra was speechless. No words could breach her closed throat. Her chest, her breathing was still. She looked down at the mask, and then back up at Adora.

Did she… did she like the mask? Did that mean she didn't like the way Catra looked?

That thought was unsettling. Maybe she did and she never told Catra. She turned away, scowling down at the mattress. "It's dumb. I felt dumb. I was a fucking idiot trying to do something like that. I'm just going to go melt it down."

Adora recoiled back and held it protectively against her chest as though it was an orphan child that Catra was about to slay. "Don't!"

"Why not?" Catra's voice was an irritated grumble. Once again, Adora telling her what to do.

Adora relaxed back, but she wouldn't give up the protective embrace of the mask. "Because you looked different with it on, but… you. Not the normal Catra, but the one… The one that I get to see sometimes. You have a… I don't know… Sometimes you're different." Her words were as subtle as a rockslide as she grasped for the right ones to say. As she spoke her arms unfolded from her chest, exposing the mask to Catra again. "Like things don't matter and you look like a different person but you're still you. It doesn't cover your face like Shadow Weaver's. It just makes things better."

"What do you mean?" Catra's irritation had subsided as Adora spoke.

"I mean that you're a really good person sometimes, but just with me. And if this helps you do that more often, then I want… I'd like it if you kept it. Sure the other cadets think it's dumb. But what do they know? I just want to see you a little bit happier. And you made this. You earned it. They'll come around." She smiled again.

The last cloud of doubt washed away from Catra's thoughts and she reached out to pluck the mask from Adora. She turned it around, raised it up, and placed it on her head. She thought it felt dumb.

But if Adora wanted to wear it, then she’d get over it.

Adora’s smile was all she needed to be brave.

Dear Catra

Adora sat back and stared down at the page, the ink shining as it dried in the cool night air. The roaring of the Bright Moon waterfalls was pervasive, but she barely heard it anymore. All the time that had passed… maybe she'd finally grown used to it. Or maybe her mind was on other things.

She read it over again.

Dear Catra,

You are my enemy now, and you always will be. I know that now. All this time, I had hope. Hope that you would see the light. Hope that you would realize that Etheria is a beautiful place that needs to be saved, and not destroyed.

I have no more hope now, and that makes me sad. So sad. Because I miss you, Catra, and I will always miss you.

I miss your smile. I miss the gleam in your eye when you would beat me in a race during training. I miss laughing with you when we would play a prank on one of the other cadets in the barracks. I even miss you snoring in the bunk above me.

Those are the things I remember when I think about you. I'm going to try to remember the good things about you, instead of the bad ones. Because those break my heart.

I'm sorry things ended up like this. I really am. But even if we could go back in time, I wouldn't do things any other way.

Each letter was like a needle straight to her heart, but it didn't hurt as much anymore. It still hurt. Just not as much. There was a steely resolve within her now. A new driving purpose. And she would keep moving forward. She had to.

Still. Just below those words, she'd signed it: *Love, Adora.*

She'd written them out before she quite knew what she was doing, and now she stared at them almost in disbelief. She couldn't untangle the mass of emotions in her chest. It was all so confusing. She'd started this stupid fake letter in an attempt to sort it all out. To put to rest what was in the past so she could move on. But as she read over those words over and over, she couldn't help but feel that resolve within her crumbling.

Maybe she was wrong. Maybe there was something else she could do. Something that would change Catra's mind. If she could just—

A burst of sparkles and light interrupted her thoughts. She jumped and hastily knocked over everything on her desk to cover up the letter as Glimmer materialized in the middle of her room.

"Adora!" she shouted despite the late hour. "Bow and I are making a cake raid. Let's go!" She pulled up short when she finally took in Adora's wide-eyed look, crouched awkwardly over her desk. "What're you doing?"

Adora straightened and cleared her throat. "Oh—uh—nothing. Just… working on my reports."

"Oh right, your *reports* ." Glimmer smirked and sidled up closer to the desk. Her eyes skimmed over the mess, but thankfully the letter was mostly obscured by a half-unrolled scroll. "Anything important in tonight's report?"

"Not really." Adora put her arm around Glimmer's shoulders and steered her away from the desk. "What's this you were saying about a cake raid?"

Glimmer clapped her hands together in excitement. Her eyes were positively shining with excitement. "It's the Third Turning Festival tomorrow so the kitchen is gonna be full of cakes! Let's go steal some before everyone else eats them."

"The Third Turning Festival?" Adora cocked her head to the side. "What's—"

"It doesn't matter! What matters is there are gonna be a bunch of unclaimed cakes *tonight* and I say *let's claim 'em!* " Glimmer clamped a hand firmly on her shoulder. "So are you in?"

Adora glanced behind her at the desk. Beneath all the random, scattered junk were those words. Words she wished she could say —words that she never would. It had felt good to write them down, however painful. And it felt good as she turned back to Glimmer.

She smiled and nodded. "Let's go."

I Look Out For You

The pen left a black streak on the last line. Those last words. It all felt like it'd be over. She didn't want it to be. It didn't feel like it should be. She'd marched into oblivion before, why would this time be any different? It seemed like a simple plan. An idea.

Who even knew where she'd wind up. Entrapta's models were good but they weren't good enough to predict the Portal space. They'd spent all night coming up with a rescue plan together. But it meant she'd have to go in alone to find her. What would she find? Reality didn't seem like it mattered there. It was the person that you took in there with yourself. And she hated who she was the last time she was there. She…

She said things that she could never take back. She felt things that she never wanted to feel. But they'd lingered in her for so long that they bubbled out like black electrified bile. She still remembered, more than being chipped by Prime, more than suffocation by Hordak, more than any zap from a princess, she'd remembered that burning hatred ever since that day.

It didn't make sense, in a way. How much that anger could drive her. It fueled her. But it was clearer in retrospect. Like it was the secret she hid from herself when the rest of the world felt it. Double Trouble had figured it out within minutes of the two of them meeting.

Scorpia tried to heal it.

Glimmer wouldn't stand for it.

Bow suffered for it.

Adora… she couldn't take it anymore.

That blow. It happened in another dimension and she felt it even now. And she wished, so many nights she wished that it'd

driven that hatred out of her. Like a cleansing beam of light, it would extinguish and everything could be okay again.

But instead it stoked the flames of hate higher. Her last desperate act to unmake the world had backfired and she lit the way with the bridges she burned.

Over.

And Over.

And Over.

It'd been her only guiding light.

Now she stood on Darla. Ready to save a woman she never met, but she hated with every ounce of her being for so long. Maybe it'd make up for things. Maybe things would be better? Maybe she could let go of that little bit of hurt.

That hurt.

The anger had burned inside of her for so long, she didn't know it was immolating her soul. In its wake was an emptiness that consumed her and drove her to heinous acts. People died in droves and she was complicit.

But here she stood on Darla.

Seeing the conclusion of hate in Horde Prime's presence. That willingness to burn absolutely everything in front of her. And he turned it on entire worlds. At a whim he'd wipe out anything that even remotely inconvenienced him.

That could've been her. Somehow, someday. She could've sat on that throne.

It was a blessing she didn't, but there were still days she wished that Adora hadn't come back for her. That she'd have

stayed away like she wanted. But she didn't. Because she's Adora. And now Catra felt empty.

Catra had tried for so long to fill that emptiness with love but it felt like collecting water in a colander. It just drained away as fast as it filled. And she wanted so badly to patch up those holes. To stand in the love with her… with her… friends. They were okay. She wasn't. And she was trying so hard to be.

It felt stupid, selfish to be in their presence and not feel loved. But it just fed that guilt. It fed the emptiness.

The fires had burned out long ago. And now echoes of the screams of her past resounded inside of the hollow hole in her being.

This was her life.

She wanted to do that one good thing. But it wasn't about that. It was about the good things that you do after that. And she wanted to be here. She wanted to be with them. But she was about to tell all of them that she was going into the Portal alone and she didn't know if she was coming back. No one knew what she was going into.

But she'd go.

She was going to find Angella.

She would bring her back home.

Catra knew she had to.

But if she didn't…

Catra folded up the letter and slipped it into an envelope. She was careful, as careful as she could be with her claws. She wanted to seal it or something, but she couldn't think of how. Maybe just a promise.

She left their room, and wandered the quiet halls of Darla. Everyone would be gathering in the mess hall soon to activate the Portal. Entrapta's work and science were about to pay off, and Catra had to convince everyone that it was her that would go in. That was the best model that they had.

Catra poked her head into Glimmer and Bow's room. The two of them sat talking with one another.

Glimmer looked up at her and smiled. "Catra! Hey!"

"Hey, Sparkles." She tried to look normal. But she knew she had tells. Sometimes it really was awful having a tail.

"Something wrong?" Bow's face brimmed with concern.

"No, well, sort of. Could maybe… Could Sparkles and I have a minute, Arrow Boy?"

Bow looked between them. He furrowed his brow in confusion. But… Glimmer nodded at him. He shrugged. "Okay, I'll see you guys in a minute."

He kissed Glimmer on her cheek and stood. He walked towards Catra with that obnoxiously happy smile he carried. No wonder he and Adora got along. As he passed, he placed a hand gently on Catra's shoulder. "Hey, it'll be okay."

She wanted to slash at his hand, get him off her. But it wasn't the time.

Catra nodded. "Thanks."

He left and Catra shut the door behind him. She and Glimmer were now in the silent room alone.

"What's this about?" Glimmer asked.

Catra crossed the room and handed the envelope to her. "If… Entrapta and I have a plan. And I need to… I am going to go into

the Portal alone and find Angella."

"By *yourself*?" Glimmer scowled. The mere suggestion of leaving her out of something always earned that look from her.

"Yes, it's… it'll make sense in a bit. You can shout at me then. I just need you to do something." Catra gently shook the envelope in front of Glimmer.

She reached up and plucked it out of her hand. "Okay, what do you need?"

No challenges, no question. Glimmer would do it if Catra needed her to.

Catra swallowed. "I need you to give this to Adora if I… If I can't come back. I need her to read it. I need her to have it. Because… because reasons."

Glimmer looked in disbelief. She held it between her hands now as if Catra just gave her a precious treasure. "You have to come back."

"I don't know if I can. I don't know if I will. And if… well, maybe it'll be a good motivation for me to come back if it means that Adora doesn't have to read this dumb poem." Catra scratched the back of her neck across the fresh scars she'd cut there a couple nights before. Into the ghost of the chip she still wore.

"It's a poem?" Glimmer asked pensively, looking up at her. "Can I read it?"

"No! What's wrong with you? I just told you that's why I want to come back!"

Glimmer's eyes shimmered in their coursicating light of her magic. "I won't tell her. I just… Can I? I'd like to read it. Or you can read it to me?"

Catra stopped. Her body went stiff, her blood chilled, how could she read it?

In her mind's eye she saw a scared child huddled in the corner of Adora's bed from so long ago. That fear. Not wanting to be found or to be seen. The blankets were wrapped so tight that they made it hard to breathe. She didn't want to be there, but she didn't know a way out.

She was scared. She was in the dark.

But there was a light. Catra knew that child. She knew what that child wanted. What they needed. It was more than a Promise. It was more than a hug.

She wanted that child to be heard. All of the things that she never got to say to Adora, the times she was sorry, the times she was afraid, the times that she wanted Adora there more than anything. She needed a voice. Catra could speak for her, and maybe it was as good of a time to start as any.

"Okay."

She took the envelope back from Glimmer, opened it, unfolded the paper, and read:

I stood there at the end of everything.

I stand there again.

Explosions in the sky of oblivion.

When bolts of anger and death rained above.

I've seen the end of times with you.

I have been there and back.

You've died in my arms.

Our love brought you back.

I've died in yours.

Our love brought me back.

I remember the nights we spent alone

Under the moons of Etheria.

Cold nights and dim hearts

But we kindled the fires in ourselves.

I try not to think of those times.

Not because of you,

But because of me.

You didn't ruin anything.

I did.

I broke the world.

You still saw me through.

You wouldn't let me go

Somehow, in the blackness of my heart

You found the light.

Shattered souls and wounded memories

They play out in the sky above.

The fury of love and the passion of anger

Two friends fight in the sky of void.

'I'm not doing this because I like you.'

How many other lies have I told?

Adora

Don't quit on me now.

Don't forget who you are inside

You're the champion of us all

And it's time we fight for you.

Glimmer's eyes streaked with glittering tears as she stared up at Catra from where she sat. "Catra, you have to come back."

"Why?"

"Because when you do, you need to read that to Adora."

Catra smirked. In a flash of light Glimmer teleported to her and wrapped Catra in a crushing embrace.

She struggled to breathe and to protest. She told herself that she was only saying this so Glimmer would let go. But that was a lie.

"I will, I promise."

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